

Sanderstead Singers Safeguarding Policy



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About the choir and context of this policy

Sanderstead Singers is a mainly adult choir which gathers to sing services in cathedrals or churches for a week each summer, plus other single days or weekends through the year.

The choir was founded in 1991 and originally used St Mary's Church, Sanderstead, as a rehearsal base, where the musical director was also organist. During this period, the choir followed the policies and procedures of that church, and this policy was originally derived from those policies and procedures.

A new musical director took over the choir upon the founder's retirement in 2019, and since then the choir has rehearsed in other churches in the Southwark Diocese. The policy has been updated to reflect these changes.

The choir has no employees or premises, but it sits within the context of various safeguarding policies and teams:

- St Edmundsbury Cathedral, where the current musical director worships (and is a former employee).
 - Diocese of St Edmundsbury and Ipswich.
- St John the Divine, Selsdon, where the choir sometimes rehearses, and where some choir members sing regularly.
- St Mary, Merton, where the choir sometimes rehearses, and where some choir members sing regularly.
 - Diocese of Southwark.
 - Church of England.

In addition, nearly all the choir's performances take place during divine worship in cathedrals in the Church of England, so the choir also sits within the context of their safeguarding teams during those visits.

The current choir leadership team is:

<i>Musical Director</i>	Daniel Soper
<i>Admin team</i>	Catherine Tempest
	Claire Weeks

This document outlines the choir's safeguarding policies and procedures, and applies to all choir activities, including rehearsals, services, group trips and residentials.

Safeguarding statements

The Church of England National Safeguarding Standards have been used to inform our statements below.

Culture, leadership and capacity

We are committed to promoting a safe and healthy culture, where:

- all members (including children and adults at risk) can feel valued and listened to,
- all members are protected from harm, and
- the welfare of children is paramount.

Leadership of the choir (musical, and administrative) is undertaken by long-standing members of the choir. When appointing people to leadership roles, the choir will consider whether the role is eligible for or would benefit from a DBS check, taking account of the nature of the role and any safeguarding requirements of host cathedrals / churches.

We endeavour to review our safeguarding needs periodically, including revision of this document. The leadership team should be prepared to refer any concerns or queries onto the relevant bodies.

Prevention

We recognise that any form of abuse (including of children and adults at risk) can occur in any community and is often likely to occur within families and by people known to the child. As a close-knit choir, we must do all we can to maintain an environment that promotes safety, minimises opportunities for abuse or inappropriate behaviour, and encourages concerns to be raised promptly.

We can do this by:

- avoiding situations which could be used inappropriately (e.g. no individual tuition of children without additional adult supervision),
- challenging all abuse of power within the choir (especially by anyone in a position of trust),
- promoting good safeguarding practice and awareness, and
- ensuring all appropriate boundaries are respected, and challenging situations where they are not.

Recognising, Assessing and Managing Risk

We recognise that a large range of risks are inherent in the running of a choir, and in performing in public spaces.

We recognise that the Christian communities in which we perform may include and support former offenders.

We recognise that the opportunity for new abuse can never be fully eradicated.

A separate risk assessment document is maintained which covers the risks commonly associated with the choir's visits. This will be revised periodically by the leadership team and may be used to generate risk assessments for specific visits.

Where appropriate, known specific risks will be shared with the relevant safeguarding bodies to ensure that they can be assessed and managed more widely.

Victims and Survivors

If anyone believes a child or adult is at immediate risk of harm, they should contact emergency services (999) without delay and then inform the leadership team

and the most relevant safeguarding body as soon as possible.

All adults in the choir should be prepared for the possibility of safeguarding disclosures.

All disclosures should be:

- responded to in a victim-centred way,
- acted on appropriately, transparently and without delay, and
- recorded clearly and passed on to the most relevant safeguarding body.

The most relevant safeguarding body will usually be the representative for the cathedral or church the choir was visiting at the time, or its diocesan adviser.

The leadership team will work with any safeguarding body openly to respond to all concerns, including when allegations are made against a member of the choir. The leadership team will make a written record of any concerns raised, and refer them to the relevant safeguarding body.

A procedure for responding to disclosures is included later in this document.

Choir safeguarding communication should go through the official choir admin email address (sandersteadsingers91@gmail.com) rather than private email accounts.

We will seek to ensure that appropriate pastoral care is offered to anybody (child, young person or adult) who has suffered abuse.

We will seek to ensure appropriate pastoral care is offered to any member of our choir against whom an allegation is made.

Learning, Supervision and Support

Several choir members already receive safeguarding training as part of volunteer or paid roles elsewhere.

At least one member of the choir leadership team should maintain current basic safeguarding training appropriate to the choir's activities.

Choir policies

The following policies apply to all rehearsals, services and events.

1. Any child under the age of 18 must be accompanied by at least one parent, guardian or designated adult (of the parent / guardian's choice) to act *in loco parentis* (the "responsible adults").
2. On residential trips, no adults may enter a child's room or share a room with a child unless they are a responsible adult or in an emergency.
3. The responsible adults are in charge of the safety and supervision of the child throughout.
4. The choir leadership team may assist with general supervision of the group (e.g. during rehearsals and services), but this does not transfer primary responsibility away from the responsible adults.
5. All other adults should avoid being alone with any child at any time.
6. Choir communication with children should normally be via parents / responsible adults.

Choir procedures

New choir members

All new choir members are asked to provide appropriate contact details, which are stored within the choir's Gmail and Google Drive account.

Parents of children joining the choir are asked to complete a registration form, which will be stored in the choir's Google Drive account.

The registration form includes:

- Full name of the child,
- Date of birth,
- Names of all parents and guardians,
- Confirmation of having read this policy,
- Acknowledgement of the expectation of the parents accompanying and supervising their child,
- The opportunity to list additional responsible adults,
- Acknowledgement of leadership team providing secondary supervision,
- Emergency contact details (address, telephone, email),
- Medical or other special needs,
- Photographic permission for:

- Private use amongst choir members, including social media, and
- Publicity use, including by the cathedral / church being visited,
- Livestreaming permission, and
- Date / signature.

Visit preparation

In preparation for a visit, the leadership team will:

- ensure that all safeguarding requirements of the cathedral / church are established and complied with,
- consider whether the risk assessment needs to be revised, or a specific assessment created for this visit,
- ensure all choir members have been made aware of this policy,
- establish an appropriate safeguarding contact to include on the 'Final letter' to the choir or other documentation, and
- ensure that all children participating have appropriate registrations on file.

Safeguarding disclosures

Anyone in the choir receiving a safeguarding disclosure should follow the procedure below.

- Listen carefully and take the person seriously.
- Avoid promising confidentiality.
- Avoid asking leading questions or investigating the matter.
- Make a written note as soon as possible of what was said and observed.
- Pass the concern promptly to the relevant cathedral / church safeguarding officer (via the leadership team if necessary).
- Contact the police or emergency services immediately if someone is in immediate danger.

Reporting concerns

If any choir member, parent, child or responsible adult has a safeguarding concern, they should report it as soon as possible to a member of the leadership team. Concerns relating to cathedral / church visits should also be reported to the relevant safeguarding officer.

If a child or adult is in immediate danger, contact the police or emergency services first.

The leadership team will keep a written record of safeguarding concerns, which will only be shared with those who need the information in order to respond appropriately.

Version history

Date	Information
April 2018	First version which is standalone from St Mary, Sanderstead's safeguarding policies.
December 2021	Further clarifications on the independence from St Mary, Sanderstead.
June 2026	Full revision of the policy, simplifying procedures and incorporating the National Safeguarding Standards.